EXERCISE 13

Phase line • Finite-time blow-up

Multi-Equilibria Autonomous Phase Line Dynamics

Original statement · ProblemsCh2.pdf, p. 3

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Consider the autonomous differential equation

$$\frac{dy}{dt} = y(y-2)(y-3).$$

In each of the following cases, what can you conclude based on the uniqueness theorem about the different solutions if

(i) $y(0) = -1$,
(ii) $y(0) = 1$,
(iii) $y(0) = 2$,
(iv) $y(0) = 4$?

Source: ProblemsCh2.pdf, Exercise 13 (page 3).

PHASE 1: CLASSIFICATION, HYPOTHESES AND DOMAIN

Autonomous equation $\dot{y} = f(y)$ with the cubic polynomial

$$f(y) = y(y-2)(y-3) = y^3 - 5y^2 + 6y, \qquad f'(y) = 3y^2 - 10y + 6.$$

Both f and f' are continuous on all of $\mathbb{R}$, so the existence and uniqueness theorem holds at every initial point: through each $(0, y_0)$ passes exactly one solution, defined on a maximal open interval of existence.

Equilibria ($f(y^*) = 0$): $y^* = 0,\ 2,\ 3$. They give the constant solutions $y \equiv 0$, $y \equiv 2$, $y \equiv 3$.

PHASE 2: CHOICE OF METHOD AND CHANGE OF VARIABLES

Why this method: by uniqueness, two different solutions of the same autonomous equation never touch. A non-constant solution therefore cannot reach an equilibrium value in finite time, so it stays in one of the four intervals

$$I_1 = (-\infty, 0), \quad I_2 = (0, 2), \quad I_3 = (2, 3), \quad I_4 = (3, \infty)$$

determined by the equilibria. Inside an interval f has a constant sign, so $y(t)$ is strictly monotone. A monotone function that stays in a bounded interval has a limit, and this limit must be an equilibrium. If the interval is unbounded, the solution may escape to infinity; whether this happens in finite time is decided by separating variables.

Sign of f and stability from f':

Interval or point	Sign of f (test point)	Motion
$y < 0$	$f(-1) = (-1)(-3)(-4) = -12 < 0$	decreasing
$0 < y < 2$	$f(1) = (1)(-1)(-2) = 2 > 0$	increasing
$2 < y < 3$	$f(2.5) = (2.5)(0.5)(-0.5) = -0.625 < 0$	decreasing
$y > 3$	$f(4) = (4)(2)(1) = 8 > 0$	increasing

Stability: $f'(0) = 6 > 0$ (unstable), $f'(2) = 12 - 20 + 6 = -2 < 0$ (asymptotically stable), $f'(3) = 27 - 30 + 6 = 3 > 0$ (unstable). This agrees with the arrows: flow leaves 0 and 3 on both sides and enters 2 from both sides.

Time scale for blow-up: for $|y|$ large, $f(y) \sim y^3$, and the time needed to reach infinity is $\int^{\infty} dy/f(y) \sim \int^{\infty} dy/y^3 < \infty$. This finite integral signals that infinity is reached in finite time. We compute the time exactly by separation of variables.

PHASE 3: STEP-BY-STEP DERIVATION

Separation of variables with partial fractions

For $y \neq 0, 2, 3$ write $\dfrac{dy}{y(y-2)(y-3)} = dt$ and decompose:

$$\frac{1}{y(y-2)(y-3)} = \frac{A}{y} + \frac{B}{y-2} + \frac{C}{y-3}.$$

Cover-up rule: $A = \frac{1}{(0-2)(0-3)} = \frac{1}{6}$, $B = \frac{1}{2\,(2-3)} = -\frac{1}{2}$, $C = \frac{1}{3\,(3-2)} = \frac{1}{3}$. Check: $A + B + C = \frac{1}{6} - \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3} = 0$, as required since the left side decays like y^{-3}. Integrating,

$$G(y) := \int \frac{dy}{y(y-2)(y-3)} = \frac{1}{6}\ln|y| - \frac{1}{2}\ln|y-2| + \frac{1}{3}\ln|y-3|.$$

Barrow's rule from $(0, y_0)$: $G(y(t)) - G(y_0) = t$. Equivalently, multiplying by 6 and exponentiating,

$$\frac{|y|\,|y-3|^2}{|y-2|^3} = K\,e^{6t}, \qquad K = \frac{|y_0|\,|y_0-3|^2}{|y_0-2|^3}.$$

Limit of G at infinity: the coefficients sum to zero, so $G(y) = \frac{1}{6}\ln\dfrac{|y|\,|y-3|^2}{|y-2|^3}$, and the argument of the logarithm tends to 1 as $y \to \pm\infty$. Hence $G(\pm\infty) = \frac{1}{6}\ln 1 = 0$.

Case (i): $y(0) = -1$

$y(0) \in I_1$. By uniqueness the solution cannot reach the equilibrium $y = 0$, so $y(t) < 0$ for all t in its domain. Since $f < 0$ there, y is strictly decreasing.

- Backward in time: y increases and is bounded above by 0, so it tends to an equilibrium: $y \to 0^-$ as $t \to -\infty$.
- Forward in time: y decreases without a lower barrier and $f \sim y^3$, so it blows up to $-\infty$ at a finite time T^*.

Blow-up time from Barrow's rule, $T^* = G(-\infty) - G(-1) = -G(-1)$:

$$G(-1) = \frac{1}{6}\ln 1 - \frac{1}{2}\ln 3 + \frac{1}{3}\ln 4, \qquad T^* = \frac{1}{2}\ln 3 - \frac{1}{3}\ln 4 = \frac{1}{2}\ln 3 - \frac{2}{3}\ln 2 \approx 0.0872.$$

Cross-check with the closed form: $K = \frac{1\cdot 16}{27}$, and blow-up occurs when the left side tends to 1 (as $|y| \to \infty$): $1 = \frac{16}{27}e^{6T^*}$, so $T^* = \frac{1}{6}\ln\frac{27}{16} = \frac{1}{6}(3\ln 3 - 4\ln 2)$, the same value.

Case (ii): $y(0) = 1$

$y(0) \in I_2 = (0, 2)$. The equilibria 0 and 2 are barriers, so $0 < y(t) < 2$ for all t. A bounded solution cannot blow up, so it is defined for all $t \in \mathbb{R}$. Since $f > 0$, y is strictly increasing, hence it has limits at both ends and they are equilibria:

$$\lim_{t\to-\infty} y(t) = 0, \qquad \lim_{t\to+\infty} y(t) = 2.$$

The solution goes from the unstable equilibrium 0 to the stable equilibrium 2 (a monotone, sigmoidal profile). Neither limit is reached in finite time.

Case (iii): $y(0) = 2$

$f(2) = 0$, so $y(t) \equiv 2$ is a solution of the IVP. By the uniqueness theorem it is the only one:

$$y(t) \equiv 2 \quad \forall t \in \mathbb{R}.$$

In particular no non-constant solution can pass through the point $(t, 2)$ at any time; solutions that start in I_2 or I_3 approach 2 only asymptotically.

Case (iv): $y(0) = 4$

$y(0) \in I_4 = (3, \infty)$. The barrier $y = 3$ gives $y(t) > 3$ for all t; $f > 0$ there, so y is strictly increasing.

- Backward in time: bounded below by 3 and decreasing as t decreases, so $y \to 3^+$ as $t \to -\infty$.
- Forward in time: no upper barrier and $f \sim y^3$, so $y \to +\infty$ at a finite time T^*.

$$T^* = G(+\infty) - G(4) = -G(4) = -\left[\frac{1}{6}\ln 4 - \frac{1}{2}\ln 2 + \frac{1}{3}\ln 1\right] = -\left[\frac{1}{3}\ln 2 - \frac{1}{2}\ln 2\right] = \frac{1}{6}\ln 2 \approx 0.1155.$$

Cross-check with the closed form: $K = \frac{4 \cdot 1}{8} = \frac{1}{2}$, and $1 = \frac{1}{2}e^{6T^*}$ gives $T^* = \frac{1}{6}\ln 2$.

PHASE 4: VERIFICATION, LIMITS AND INTERPRETATION

Numerical checks (computed): the partial-fraction decomposition from sympy is $\frac{1}{6y} - \frac{1}{2(y-2)} + \frac{1}{3(y-3)}$, matching A, B, C. An independent fourth-order Runge-Kutta integration of $\dot{y} = y(y-2)(y-3)$ with step 1.5×10^{-6} reaches $|y| > 10^7$ at $t \approx 0.115526$ for $y_0 = 4$ (formula: 0.115525) and at $t \approx 0.087210$ for $y_0 = -1$ (formula: 0.087208).

Time scale: the correct statement for $y_0 = -1$ and $y_0 = 4$ is not $y \to \pm\infty$ as $t \to \infty$; the solutions cease to exist at $T^* \approx 0.087$ and $T^* \approx 0.116$ respectively, so a limit $t \to \infty$ is meaningless for them. By contrast, for $y_0 = 1$ the solution is global and the limit $t \to \infty$ is 2.

Dimensional remark: if y is a non-dimensional state and t is measured in units of a characteristic time τ, then T^* is a number of such units; the equation $\dot{y} = f(y)$ requires $[f] = [y]/[t]$, and the coefficients $2, 3$ carry the dimensions of y.

CLASSIFICATION OF TRAJECTORIES

Initial condition	Region	Behavior forward	Behavior backward
(i) $y(0) = -1$	$y < 0$, decreasing	blow-up to $-\infty$ at $T^* = \frac{1}{2}\ln 3 - \frac{2}{3}\ln 2 \approx 0.087$	$y \to 0^-$ as $t \to -\infty$
(ii) $y(0) = 1$	$0 < y < 2$, increasing	$y \to 2$ as $t \to \infty$	$y \to 0^+$ as $t \to -\infty$
(iii) $y(0) = 2$	equilibrium	$y \equiv 2$	$y \equiv 2$
(iv) $y(0) = 4$	$y > 3$, increasing	blow-up to $+\infty$ at $T^* = \frac{1}{6}\ln 2 \approx 0.116$	$y \to 3^+$ as $t \to -\infty$

Study notes written from the official course material (ProblemsCh2.pdf; Robinson (2004).pdf · p. 56). Online version: subjects/advanced-maths/problemas/topic-2-problems.html